

## The Web SOCIALITE

**MARK ZUCKERBERG** The 25-year-old CEO of Facebook who launched the social networking service from his Harvard dorm room in 2004 is now one of the most influential people in the world.



**ORKUT BUYUKOKTEN** Turkish-born software engineer and senior Google employee who developed the eponymous social

networking site, the only one to be named after its creator.



**JONATHAN ABRAMS** Canadian-Jewish engineering school dropout and Silicon Valley software techie who formerly worked at Netscape before launching Friendster in 2003. Hailed as a social pioneer, he was eclipsed by Zuckerberg's Facebook.



### SPIN-OFFS

#### Virtual Codes

**Poke** A virtual "thinking of you" jab. The next level is the superpoke.

#### Testimonials

Comments by friends on your profile. Facebook calls it the wall, Orkut calls it testimonials.

**Newsfeed** Live updates about what your friends are doing.

**Status update** What you are doing right now.

ceived when someone touches you online. The mobile is the new online. In that sense Google's Orkut has over 7.1 million users.

Yet the civics of this world smells of rabid hate-groups, stalkers, obsessive editorial writers and sexual obsessives. Unlike in Thailand, where sms organised protests challenging the state or in China where it creates dissent, Indian social network seems placid. If Orkut feels down-market, Facebook is more starched, with a touch of the Rotarian. It is more of a public school. It has brand value. Advertisers gorge on it for its upmarket look.

When one reads interviews and reports about why social networking attracts people, the standard shibboleths of privacy, freedom, impact and participation are cited. One wonders whether this rudimentary sociology works. Such answers work better in criticising the conventionally social. The social network as a parallel world reveals the lack of freedom and participation in our society. What it does not explain is the content of networking. What one observes here is not privacy but the need for play, for the agon, for quizzes and contests, for gossip and the potlatch. It is the exhibitionism of the bloated virtual self that modern life had turned arid. It is as if one needs to be twice born on Facebook to come alive. One wishes the rituals of the twice born were more ethnographically suggestive. What official life destroys is the self as spectacle and as specimen. The manipulative focus on markets diminishes the understanding of the social. Social networking is almost always presented as a marketing coup, a customer response or promotional technique.

Bryan Marshall in his surveys comparing American and Indian students suggests that Indians are more open about personal information. Indians are more complicit with strangers, than Americans, but few seek to meet their ritual friends outside the images of virtuality. Americans are more proactive and use Facebook to convert online into shore-line friendships. Social networking adds

to equality and esteem. It gives the dignity of citizenship without being interrogated. Yet, there seems to be some cultural difference which we need to pen down. Is the dominance of Orkut in India, Bibbo in UK, Cyworld in Korea, a fact of cultural style or just a result of entrepreneurship? Indians in fact, seem to be less concerned with privacy. They are more ready to share telephone numbers, e-mail addresses, more open to contact with strangers. Americans use social networking to secede from the older generation. Indians use social networking to subjugate parents who are in awe of what they don't understand.

As the world of network multiplies, new forms beyond Orkut emerge, the nature of these sites will change. In modern times, where major software localisation is still taking baby steps, the commons of social have already been localised. Facebook has innovated with the introduction of five languages, including Bengali, Hindi, Telugu, Malayalam and Tamil. It is creating a new swarm translation of words called crowd sourcing but one wonders whether translations are critical or whether Hinglish will dominate this stage of networking. Probably later,

as portals diversify, the market might shift to local languages. Hinglish as a link language might block the development of such innovations.

Peter Drucker in his wise way argued that the information revolution is complete only when institutions and mentalists match technologies. In a Druckerian sense, the revolution is still not complete. Authority is still Victorian. In a leading institute, one cannot access the word 'Sussex', because it has the word sex in it. We need liberation of mindsets that social networking may yet have to trigger but the possibilities are truly exciting.

WE WANT TO  
BUILD A SPACE  
where people get  
to know each  
other through a  
more meaningful  
interaction  
than just  
friendship.

PARAG  
CHORDIA &  
PRERNA GUPTA  
FOUNDERS, YAARI

Shiv Visvanathan  
is a social  
anthropologist

